

QUOTA PLEASE
A Jat protest for reservations at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, Mar. 2017

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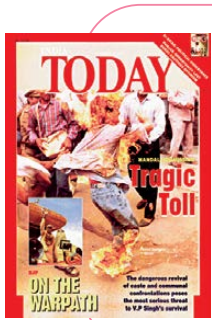
MANDAL MOMENTUM

» **Gave rise to caste-based parties such as SP, BSP and RJD and political leaders like Lalu Prasad in Bihar and Mayawati and Mulayam Singh in Uttar Pradesh, propelling them to power in these states**

» **Led to consolidation of Hindu identity and the rise of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement**

» **Sparked agitations by other communities for a slice of the quota pie**

» **Formed basis for Mandal 2.0, as the demand for a caste census is being called**



FROM THE ARCHIVES
Oct. 15, 1990

Cover Story
A Tragic Price

Almost overnight, campuses were politicised. The agitation also divided students along caste lines. Said Harinder Kumar, a political science research scholar: "We used to have Hindu vs Stephen's or Miranda vs LSR rivalries. Now they are forcing us to think on caste lines."
–Pankaj Pachauri et al

themselves of quotas. Caste politics itself is no longer the preserve of caste-based parties, the BJP too has learnt to play the game without forsaking the Hindutva agenda. The Congress found itself a whole new plank in asking for a nationwide caste census. The one that Nitish Kumar conducted in Bihar in 2022 revealed OBCs and Extremely Backward Classes to form nearly 63 per cent of the state's population, strengthening the case for increasing quotas beyond the SC-mandated 50 per cent cap. 'Mandal 2.0', as it is being called, purports to collect empirical data on caste-based disparities, to enable more targeted and expansive policymaking. Critics see it as nothing more than a calculated move to revive caste-based electoral politics. The BJP, already running late on the decennial census and wary of upsetting either its upper caste or OBC voters in the prelude to a general election, skirted the question and allocated 10 per cent quotas for economically weaker sections (EWS) instead.

The Mandal Commission's legacy remains complex. It has empowered historically marginalised communities, opened new routes for social mobility, and dismantled entrenched hierarchies. At the same time, it has sparked enduring debates about merit, equity, and the limits of affirmative action. Politically, it has ensured vote bank politics never runs out of fodder. Mandal's social justice agenda and Kamandal's cultural unification project will continue to shape India's political and social evolution. The flames Rajiv Goswami's tragic act of defiance ignited continue to burn, urging the nation to reconcile its divided past with its aspirations for an equitable and inclusive future. ■



"Caste census was done only once, in 1931. Even when Mandal report was implemented, lack of numbers was a problem. The PM should order a caste census now"

— MULAYAM SINGH YADAV
Late Samajwadi Party chief in 2012